The Stone That Ice Would Not Carry

Student copy (project or hand out)

The following examines how researchers traced the origin of Stonehenge's central Altar Stone and weighed whether ice or human hands carried it the length of Britain.

1 Ice is patient. People are deliberate. The flat slab at the heart of Stonehenge, the one called the Altar Stone, asks which of those two moved it, and a 2026 study says the answer is the second.

2 Begin with the rock itself. It is sandstone, about sixteen feet long, more than thirteen thousand pounds, six tonnes of single stone laid flat where the great uprights meet. For years its birthplace was put somewhere in Wales, near the smaller bluestones around it. The new work moves it much farther. The grains in it match the Orcadian Basin, the old sandstone country of northeast Scotland, more than four hundred and fifty miles from Salisbury Plain. The team behind the finding worked across several institutions, with Curtin University in Australia and Sheffield Hallam, Sheffield, Bristol, and Wessex Archaeology in Britain.

3 How they fixed the source is its own kind of patience: they read the ages locked inside individual mineral grains, the tiny clocks a rock keeps from the day it formed, and matched that signature against the rock of the far north. The match held. A slab quarried near the top of the island had ended up at the bottom of it, set among stones added to the monument somewhere between roughly 2620 and 2480 B.C.E.

4 Then the harder question. A stone can travel without anyone choosing to move it. Glaciers drag boulders for hundreds of miles and drop them where the ice dies, far from where they began, and for a six-tonne block that is no small possibility. So the researchers built a model of where the old ice sheets flowed. The ice, they found, could plausibly have carried rock as far as Dogger Bank, the drowned land now under the North Sea between Britain and the continent. It does not reach southern England. The glaciers stop short of Stonehenge.

5 Which leaves the gap to be closed by hands. If the ice could not deliver the stone, then people did: hundreds of kilometres of it, over land and water, by what the work describes as coordinated effort across communities. Remy Veness, the glaciologist who ran the ice-flow modelling, is the one who drew that line where the ice gives out. Anthony Clarke, a co-lead author, put the conclusion plainly. "Rather than being carried naturally by ice, the evidence points to a deliberate, carefully planned movement across a challenging and varied landscape."

6 What that movement actually looked like, the study does not claim to know. The route is unrecovered. The method, whether sledge or raft or some long relay of both, is not in the rock. The grains can name the quarry and the ice can be ruled out, and still the four hundred and fifty miles in between stay a blank the science has narrowed but not filled. A people who left no writing moved a stone the length of their island and told no one how, and the henge keeps that part to itself.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the fourth paragraph, the writer introduces the possibility that glaciers moved the stone primarily in order to

- A) show that the ice-sheet model was the least reliable part of the research
- B) argue that the earlier Welsh-origin theory was the more likely account
- C) suggest that the stone's weight made any human transport impossible
- D) raise and then rule out a natural explanation before crediting human effort

2. In context, the final sentence of the last paragraph ("A people who left no writing... keeps that part to itself") most contributes to the passage's tone of

- A) mounting alarm at a discovery that unsettles settled history
- B) measured wonder held in check by candor about what is unknown
- C) brisk confidence that the central mystery has been solved
- D) gentle irony at the expense of the researchers' overreach

Discussion questions:

1. The piece spends a full paragraph building the case that glaciers could have moved the stone before setting that case aside. How does granting the natural explanation real weight change the force of the conclusion that people moved it?

2. The writer ends not on the discovery but on what remains unknown: the route and the method. What does closing on an admitted limit, rather than on the achievement, do to how you read the researchers' authority?

Writing prompt (Q2 rhetorical analysis):

The following passage examines how researchers traced the origin of Stonehenge's Altar Stone and weighed whether ice or human effort carried it across Britain. Read the passage carefully. Then, in a well-written essay, analyze the rhetorical choices the writer makes to convey an attitude toward both what the research has established and what remains unknown.